the BJP comes from regional parties like the Trinamool Congress in West Bengal or the DMK in Tamil Nadu. Even in these areas, it is looking to follow an acquisition model, like usurping the BJD's space in Odisha in a post-Naveen Patnaik era or aligning with the AIADMK in Tamil Nadu. The fact is that regional parties can push the BJP back in state elections. Nationally, however, the absence of a strong opposing national party with ground strength gives it an inordinate advantage in parliamentary polls.

A telling illustration of the rising gap between the BJP and the Congress is the number of Lok Sabha seats in which candidates from the two parties forfeited their security deposits. Candidates forfeit their deposits with the Election Commission when they fail to win more than one-sixth of the votes polled in their constituency.[79] It is, therefore, a good measure for gauging the rising irrelevance of a party in a particular area. In 2009, BJP candidates forfeited their deposits in as many as 170 seats, the Congress only in seventy-one. By 2019, that equation had almost reversed. The BJP forfeited deposits in only fifty-one seats nationally in 2019. The Congress did so in almost three times as many seats (148). In other words, in almost one-third of India's parliamentary seats, the Congress had become electorally irrelevant within the course of a decade. What this shift means for both parties is evident (see Figure 18.3).

By the beginning of 2021, as the Congress continued to grapple with the question of Rahul Gandhi and the dynasty's leadership, one fact was inescapable. Not only had Sonia Gandhi been president of the party for over two decades (with a short interval for her son in between), most of its top faces had also virtually been the same in this period. Most of the party's top leaders, including the so-called 'Gang of 23', which asked for leadership changes, came from the same cohort that I had encountered as a young beat reporter covering the party two decades earlier. They were essentially the same generation that had battled Vajpayee and Advani's BJP in the late 1990s. By contrast, the BJP's top office-bearers under Modi in 2020 were virtually unrecognisable from the team he and Shah inherited in 2014.

The average age of the BJP's national office-bearers appointed under J.P. Nadda's presidency in 2019 was about fifty. In that same